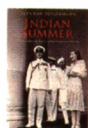


AN ENCHANTED PAST

Traversing territory covered extensively by past historians, Tunzelmann has few secrets to reveal but offers a colourful account of the extraordinary lives of the Mountbattens and Nehru



INDIAN SUMMER: THE SECRET HISTORY OF THE END OF AN EMPIRE
by ALEX VON TUNZELMANN
Simon & Schuster
Price: £20; Pages: 464

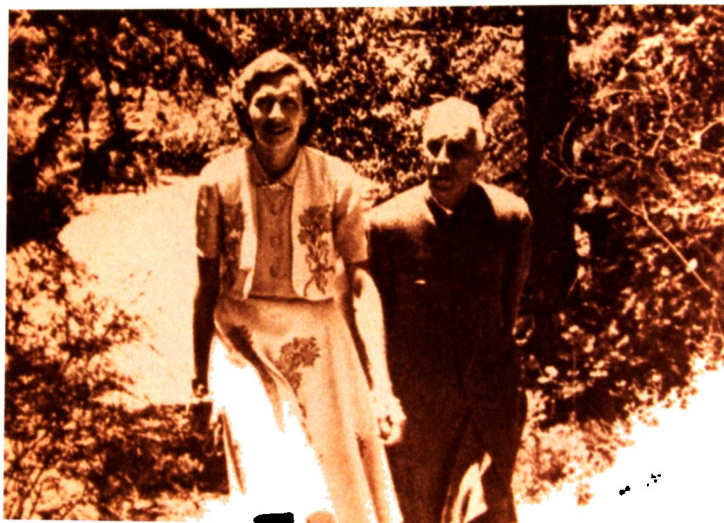
■ By Gillian Wright

The anniversary of 60 years of Independence has provided an opportunity for a whole crop of authors to re-examine recent Indian history. Among them the only eyewitness to the era is the distinguished former diplomat Narendra Singh Sarila who himself served as ADC to the Viceroy, Lord Mountbatten. The seemingly inexhaustible Ramachandra Guha, meanwhile, has concentrated on the period after Independence.

The latest of these books is *Indian Summer: The Secret History of the End of an Empire* by Alex von Tunzelmann. Sarila's thesis is that Archibald Wavell was the main architect of Partition, but Tunzelmann, more conventionally, gives that role to Mountbatten and those he dealt with. Her book is in fact largely biography. She focuses on the immensely complex developments before and after Independence through the characters of the people she believes made modern India—Gandhi, Jinnah, Nehru and the Mountbattens. Of these, she concentrates most on the last three and the effect their friendship had on India. And if this book has a hero or heroine, it is Edwina Mountbatten.

Edwina comes across as the People's Princess, rising almost Diana-like above a troubled marriage. She is an immediate hit with the Mahatma, visits 'untouchables', and pursues innumerable charitable works. She tones down the outdated formalities of the viceregal palace and saves her husband's career more than once, notably when she persuades Nehru to accept dominion status for India.

Critics abroad have already hailed Tunzelmann as a wonderful historian with a wit and eye for character, and



VICEREGAL VIGNETTES: (Clockwise from top) Edwina Mountbatten and Nehru shared a special relationship; Delhi crowds greet the Viceroy on August 15, 1947; Lord Mountbatten and Jinnah on Pakistan's Independence Day

her book as even-handed and authoritative. There is no doubt that she writes brilliantly and the battery of footnotes bear witness to her research. She has remarkable command of her subject but her focus on the Mountbattens makes it impossible for this book to be a truly authoritative record of the era. And, despite the title, there are few secrets between its covers.

This period of history has received

so much attention that secrets are hard to come by. Denied access to the private correspondence of Edwina and Nehru, Tunzelmann has to recreate their love affair by drawing on other evidence. Chief among her sources is the biography of Edwina by Janet Morgan, who was able to examine the hundreds of letters exchanged between Edwina and Nehru. Morgan reached the firm conclusion that the two loved each other,